

CUSTOMER & MVP BLUEPRINT

CertiGuard AI — AI-Powered Certificate Fraud Detection & Verification Platform | Market: India | Prepared July 2026

1 Executive Summary

CertiGuard AI uses OCR, computer vision and machine learning to deliver instant, automated detection of forged, edited or fabricated academic and professional certificates for institutions, employers and recruiters in India. The problem is real and economically damaging; the venture sits in a genuine white-space — AI-forensic detection on *existing* paper/scanned certificates — that neither government digital infrastructure (DigiLocker/NAD) nor manual/BPO verification vendors currently serve well. The company is pre-revenue and pre-pilot: a working prototype exists, but demand validation (paying customers, LOIs, structured HR/admissions surveys) is still missing. Verdict from the underlying diligence memo: **Founder-Market Fit 7.2/10, Overall Validation 6.4/10, Recommendation: Conditional Go**. The single highest-leverage next step is securing 2–3 pilot institutions willing to test real, anonymized certificate batches.

Dimension	Summary
Startup Idea	AI-powered SaaS + API that forensically verifies academic/professional certificates (incl. legacy paper/scanned documents) using OCR + computer vision + ML, returning a fraud-risk score in minutes.
Problem	Certificate & degree fraud (fake marksheets, forged experience letters, degree mills) is widespread in India. Current verification is manual, phone-based or BPO-driven — slow (days–weeks) and inconsistent.
Target Customers	Phase 1: mid-to-large private universities/colleges and recruitment/staffing agencies (500–20,000 students or 5,000+ annual verifications) in Tier-1/2 Indian cities. Phase 2: government bodies and large enterprises.
Key Competitors	AuthBridge/IDfy (manual BPO verification), DigiLocker/NAD (govt, forward-looking digital records only), blockchain credentialing issuers, global players (Credly-type, not India-localized), and the status quo of manual in-house checks.
Validation Insights	Prototype built (strong signal); faculty/peer feedback informal & positive (weak-moderate); no paying pilot, LOI, or formal HR/admissions survey yet (all missing). Problem is externally well-validated; product-specific demand is not.

2 Ideal Customer Profile & Buyer Persona

Ideal Customer Profile

Attribute	Profile
Org type	Mid/large private universities, autonomous colleges, recruitment & staffing agencies (Phase 1); govt bodies, large enterprises (Phase 2)
Size	500–20,000 students, or 5,000+ annual placements/verifications
Geography	Tier-1/2 Indian cities with high admissions/hiring volume (Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad, Delhi-NCR, Chennai, Mumbai)
Buying trigger	Recent fraud incident, upcoming NAAC/NBA accreditation audit, or hiring volume outgrowing manual checks
Budget holder	Registrar/Admissions Head (education); HR Head/Talent Acquisition Lead (agencies, corporates)
Tech readiness	Has digitized records/scans; open to a lightweight API or web portal integration

Buyer Persona — “Priya Menon,” Admissions Registrar / HR Compliance Lead

Attribute	Detail
Role	Registrar at a mid-size private university, or Talent Acquisition Manager at a recruitment agency
Profile	32–48 years old, 8–15 years in admissions/HR operations
Goals	Protect institutional/employer reputation, reduce compliance risk, speed up cycles, pass accreditation audits cleanly
Frustrations	Manual cross-checking is slow & understaffed; fraud surfaces after the fact; existing tools are enterprise-priced or not India-specific
Decision style	Risk-averse; needs Dean/CHRO sign-off; trusts pilot proof over marketing claims
What convinces her	A short, low-risk pilot on real (anonymized) documents showing accuracy, turnaround time, and data-privacy assurances

3 Top 10 Customer Pain Points

- Verification backlog during peak admissions/hiring season delays offers and enrollment decisions.
- Fraud discovered *after* enrollment or hiring is far costlier (legal, reputational, refund/severance) than catching it upfront.
- Manual process depends on individual staff judgment — inconsistent accuracy, no audit trail.
- Cross-institution/cross-state verification (phoning issuing colleges) is slow and often unresponsive.
- Accreditation bodies (NAAC/NBA) increasingly expect a documented verification process, not informal checks.
- Enterprise background-check vendors are priced for large corporates, leaving smaller colleges/agencies underserved.
- Most existing tools confirm a record *exists* in a database — they don't detect physical/digital tampering.
- Legacy paper and scanned certificates have no digital verification path; DigiLocker/NAD only covers newly-issued digital records.
- Few India-focused tools offer a simple plug-in API for admissions or ATS/HRMS systems.
- No published accuracy benchmarks exist for AI verification tools, leaving buyers unsure whether to trust the output.

4 Customer Journey

Stage	Buyer Activity	CertiGuard AI's Role
Awareness	Learns of certificate-fraud risk via news, a peer institution, or an internal incident	Fraud-trend content/case studies; SEO and LinkedIn outreach to registrars/HR heads
Consideration	Compares manual-process cost vs. automated tools; researches vendors	Clear comparison messaging vs. manual/BPO verification; transparent accuracy & turnaround claims
Purchase	Runs a pilot on a sample batch, then seeks Dean/CHRO sign-off and procurement/security review	Fast white-glove pilot with a fraud-risk report in hours; simple per-check/per-seat pricing and SLA
Retention	Integrates into admissions/ATS workflow; renews annually and expands to more departments	Guided onboarding/API docs; usage dashboards, accuracy reporting, upsell to bulk/API/enterprise tier

5 Key Buying Triggers & Objections

Buying Triggers	Likely Objections
Recent fraud incident at their institution or a peer institution	"How accurate is the AI, really? What's the false-positive rate?"
Upcoming NAAC/NBA accreditation cycle requiring documented rigor	"Where is our data stored — is it DPDP-compliant?"
Scaling admissions/hiring volume beyond manual team capacity	"You're a student project/early-stage — can we trust reliability and support?"
A competitor or peer institution adopts AI verification first	"What's the cost per check vs. our current in-house/manual cost?"
Government/board mandate for stronger anti-fraud controls	"Will this integrate with our existing ERP/ATS without heavy IT work?"

6 MVP Recommendation

Question	Answer
Build First	Core forensic-verification engine (OCR + tampering/CV detection) for common Indian certificate formats, a simple upload portal, and a fraud-risk score report — wrapped in a fast, white-glove pilot workflow for 2–3 target organizations.
Do NOT Build (yet)	Full ATS/HRMS integrations, blockchain issuance features, multi-country localization, enterprise SSO/security certifications, government-scale integration, or a mobile app — all deferred until pilot demand is proven.
Success Metrics	≥3 pilot organizations engaged • ≥90% detection accuracy on a real-world genuine+forged test batch • <5 min turnaround per verification • ≥1 organization signaling budget/LOI interest.

7 MoSCoW Prioritization

Priority	Items
Must Have	OCR text/field extraction • forensic tampering-detection engine • fraud-risk score output • basic web upload portal • data-retention/privacy policy (DPDP-aligned) • pilot onboarding flow
Should Have	Usage/accuracy dashboard • API for HRMS/ATS integration • batch upload processing • human-in-the-loop review queue for flagged documents
Could Have	Mobile app • multi-language document support • blockchain-issuance layer • NAD/DigiLocker partnership integration
Won't Have (now)	Enterprise SSO/full compliance certifications • multi-country localization • in-house issuance platform • fully-automated legal determinations with no human review

8 Pricing Hypothesis

Anchor below enterprise background-check vendors and position CertiGuard AI as an *add-on forensic layer*, not a full BGV replacement:

- Per-check pricing for smaller colleges and recruitment agencies — low commitment, easy pilot conversion.
- Per-seat / annual subscription tier for larger universities and enterprise HR teams once volume justifies it.
- Freemium pilot offer (e.g., first N verifications free) to remove adoption friction and generate benchmark data.
- Refine actual price points only after pilot willingness-to-pay signals are collected — treat current pricing as a hypothesis to test, not a final model.

9 Top 5 Risks

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
False positives/negatives erode trust in a compliance-sensitive use case	Medium	High	Publish accuracy benchmarks; keep a human-in-the-loop review step rather than fully automated rejection
Long institutional sales cycles (budget cycles, committee approvals)	High	Medium	Target recruitment agencies and smaller institutes first — faster decisions — before large universities
Data privacy/student & candidate data handling concerns	Medium	High	Clear retention policy, encryption, avoid storing raw documents longer than necessary; DPDP Act compliance from day one
Founder is a full-time student — limited bandwidth for sales/support	High	Medium	Start with a narrow pilot scope; add a co-founder/advisor for GTM; use academic breaks strategically
Govt/DigiLocker expansion reduces addressable legacy-document market over time	Medium	Medium	Position as the layer serving non-digitized/legacy and international documents; consider partnering, not competing

10 30-Day MVP Plan

Week	Focus	Key Actions
Wk 1	Problem & customer discovery	15–20 short interviews with registrars, HR/TA leads & agencies; document pain points and willingness-to-pay; shortlist 5–10 pilot targets
Wk 2	Pilot outreach & data prep	Send a 1-page pilot proposal to shortlisted organizations; collect anonymized sample certificates (genuine + known-forged) to stress-test the model
Wk 3	Pilot execution	Run 2–3 pilots on real/anonymized batches; measure accuracy, false-positive rate, and turnaround time; gather structured feedback
Wk 4	Synthesis & next-stage plan	Compile results into a case-study one-pager; refine per-check/per-seat pricing; decide Go/Pivot/No-Go; if Go, build a landing page + outreach list

11 Founder Action Sheet — Top 10 Next Actions

- Draft and send a 1-page pilot proposal to 10 target institutions/agencies this week.
- Conduct 15–20 interviews with registrars, HR/TA leads, and recruitment agencies.
- Build a benchmark test set of known-genuine and known-forged certificates.
- Identify and onboard an advisor/mentor with HR-tech, admissions, or compliance experience.
- Shortlist 5–10 pilot organizations, prioritizing agencies over large universities for speed.
- Run 2–3 real/anonymized document pilots; measure accuracy, false-positive rate, turnaround time.
- Draft a data-retention and privacy policy aligned to India's DPDP Act.
- Publish accuracy benchmarks and build the human-in-the-loop review step into the MVP.
- Compile pilot results into a case-study one-pager; refine per-check/per-seat pricing.
- Decide Go/Pivot/No-Go; if Go, build a lightweight landing page and a 90-day outreach list.

12 Scores & Final Verdict

Metric	Score (/100)	Rationale
Customer Clarity	60	ICP and persona are sharply defined, but demand is inferred, not yet confirmed by a formal survey (n>20 not conducted).
Problem Severity	80	Certificate fraud is well-documented, recurring, and economically damaging across admissions and hiring.
PMF Potential	55	Clear competitive white-space (forensic detection of legacy documents), but zero paying customers or LOIs so far.
MVP Readiness	50	A working OCR/CV/ML prototype exists, but it hasn't been pilot-tested on real institutional data or workflows.

FINAL VERDICT

■ **PROMISING BUT UNVALIDATED**

The problem is real and severe, and the founder has strong technical fit plus a genuine market gap to fill. But with no paying pilot, no LOI, and no formal demand survey yet, this sits between problem-solution fit and product-market fit — matching the underlying diligence memo's **Conditional Go**. The next 30–60 days of pilot validation (Section 10) determine whether this moves to a Strong Demand Signal or should pivot (e.g., agencies-first, or an API-first / B2B2G model).

Synthesized from the founder's Startup Validation Report (July 2026); market-sizing and scoring figures there are directional estimates, not audited data.